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competing needs on prohibition



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NO PEG HERE Women organisations protest lax liquor checks in Ahmedabad

"destroyed". A big change from the forbidding protocol that awaited anyone wishing to have a drink earlier.

The objective of the Bhupendra Patel government's December 22 decision is clear: it's aimed at attracting prospective international and domestic business, taking away one big minus point as they consider setting up offices and residences in the state. It's also an aperitif—a test case, perhaps, before prohibition is relaxed in other areas proposed as hubs for global business, international sports/cultural events and tourism. According to the buzz, those in line for exemptions include the Surat Diamond Bourse, Ektanagar (which houses the Statue of Unity), the Rann Utsav held in the Great Rann of Kutch and high-end hospitality outlets in Ahmedabad that will see footfalls during international sports jamborees.

No official has confirmed the speculation, but GIFT city received its gift in time for New Year's Eve. Coming on the heels of the Tharad incident, it also highlighted the paradox inherent in Gujarat's two-tier prohibition: a permissive nod for high-end urban segments, rural clampdown. Interestingly, both parts have attracted criticism from all quarters for lacking sincerity, whether in enforcing a dry policy or in relaxing it.

THE HOSPITALITY ANGLE

The first such relaxation had come in December 2023, when GIFT City employees were allowed to invite guests with a letter of authorisation issued by the company HR. It didn't do much to boost non-government event visitors to GIFT; the new relaxation may not either. "The state charges 66 per cent duty on liquor served in GIFT City, making it a prohibitively expensive luxury product," says Sapan Jani, director of Ahmedabad's Crowne Plaza Hotel, adding these part-waivers do nothing to boost the local hospitality business. Senior officials are unequivocal, though. "The relaxation is only for high-end social drinking to meet international events standards, not to facilitate consumption for locals," says one.

Ahmedabad-Gandhinagar will host the 2030 Commonwealth Games. Famously, there's the 2036 Summer Olympics bid. At least half-a-dozen international sporting events dot the calendar, and several high-profile culture and entertainment events are planned to prep the cities for the big events. But what seems kosher in that light is still open to accusations of discrimination, so it's demanding some complicated political balancing from the government to rationalise away the dichotomy.

Mevani's janta raids found much resonance with backward communities across the state. To try and dissipate that, deputy CM Harsh Sanghvi, who also handles home, thought it better not to engage directly with Mevani's accusations, and instead focus on the language he used with police officers while accusing them of being in cahoots with liquor den operators. That helped divert the conversation towards police morale and the appropriateness of the legislator's behaviour, rather than clarify the lapse in policy implementation.

"Police and politicians in Gujarat thrive on liquor *hafta*. There's no prohibition here. Liquor is freely available due to bootlegger networks, and the victims of such cheap, spurious liquor are poor communities in the villages, and the women and children who are consequently abused," says Mevani. In 2018, Mevani had led a similar janta raid and raised these allegations after four people were hospitalised in Ahmedabad after consuming hooch.

"Alcohol is a sensitive issue in rural Gujarat. Women's safety in public spaces—a greatly valued feature here—is credited to prohibition, however slack it is. Before coming to power, the BJP's stated stand was against prohibition, but it would be political suicide for any party to remove it completely," says Gaurang Jani, former head of sociology, Gujarat University. Later this year, the debate will come up in the Gujarat High Court—it will hear a petition which argues that the state shouldn't interfere with private choices. ■

Takeaways

- **Out-of-state consumers can now drink in exclusive, cordoned areas in GIFT City**
- **Being hospitable to global business, sports events calls for liberal policy; locals irate**